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Belarusian Lacinka



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A small companion for reading and writing Belarusian in Latin letters. All explanations and instructions are in English; Belarusian examples appear in Cyrillic and łacinka.

This book uses traditional ł/l, modern v, and Č, Š, Ž, ŭ. It is not a passport romanization guide. Historical books may use different conventions.

Most drills preserve the spelling of the supplied modern Cyrillic word. Classical spelling is shown separately. Changing scripts does not automatically mean changing orthography.

Follow the stork through the margins: arrival, flight, a nest, a companion, chicks, and a shared sky.

MD B6 Slim · 105 × 175 mm

Private illustrated edition · 0.2



Your reading path

Pages	Explore
4-7	Origins, writers and old editions
8-10	Letters and combinations
11-15	Ŭ, ł/l, softness and spelling
16-17	Words and a first reading
18-20	Practice and answers
21-22	Handwriting and a weekly rhythm
23-26	Poetry: freedom, spirit and flight
27-28	Sources and printing

Start with the alphabet and try the exercises. Then return to the historical pages and poetry. Page numbers include the cover.

The stork's story is an illustrated thread, not an account of the history of the alphabet.

A different script. The same language.
бyceн / busieł / stork



Who invented it?

No single established inventor can be named. Belarusian łacinka developed as a tradition of writing Belarusian in Latin letters, rather than as one person's invention on one particular date. [1, 2]

Early surviving examples are associated with the late sixteenth century. In the seventeenth century, Belarusian dialogue was recorded in Latin script, including theatrical interludes. Polish graphic conventions strongly influenced early practice. [1]

During the nineteenth century, łacinka became an important vehicle for modern Belarusian literature. Letters and spelling conventions continued to change; today's chart cannot simply be imposed on every old edition. [1, 2]

Ask who wrote, printed, circulated and codified it.



Writers and books

Vincient Dunin-Marcinkievič: his Belarusian translation of the first two books of Pan Tadeusz appeared in Vilnius in 1859 in Latin script and was confiscated. This was the Belarusian translation, not Mickiewicz's Polish original. [1, 6]

Francišak Bahuševič: Dudka bielaruskaja appeared in Kraków in 1891 under the name Maciej Buračok. Smyk bielaruski followed in 1894 under Symon Reŭka z-pad Barysava. Both were printed in łacinka. [5]

Kastuś Kalinoŭski: editor and one of the authors of Mužyckaja praŭda (1862-1863), a newspaper printed in Latin script. His role here is chiefly that of publicist and editor. [7]

An author, an editor and a codifier play different roles.



Readers and reformers

Ciotka (Alaiza Paškievič): the publisher's advertisement in Kupala's *Žalejka* (1908) lists her *Pieršaje cytaŋnie dla dzieťak biełarusaŋ* alongside a Cyrillic edition. This is evidence of a text published in both scripts. [6]

Janka Kupała: *Huślar* (1910) is a concrete example of his poetry in Latin script. This does not make every edition of his work Latin-script: the inspected *Žalejka* (1908) has a Cyrillic main text. [6, 8]

Branisłaŋ Taraškievič: his school grammar appeared in Vilnius in 1918 in both scripts. He codified an existing language and writing tradition; he did not invent *łacinka* from nothing. [4]

A printed Latin edition is not automatically evidence of a Latin-script autograph.



Inside an old edition

You may encounter	Here we use
sz	š
cz	č
ż	ž
w	v

These are reading clues, not universal correction rules. Historical editions differ in both graphic conventions and spelling. [2, 8]

Record the author, title, date and script. Compare recurring words before calling an unfamiliar spelling a mistake.

Keep two lines in your notes: 'as printed' and 'my modern rendering'. Never silently modernize a quotation.

Łacinka is a script tradition.
Taraškievica is an orthographic system.



Letters · A to K

Latin	Cyrillic / reading cue
A a	а
B b	б
C c	ц
Ć ć	ць · soft c
Č č	ч
D d	д
E e	э
F f	ф
G g	г · a stop, distinct from h
H h	Belarusian р
I i	і
J j	й
K k	к

Correspondences: [2, 3]. Do not read e, c or j as English letters. The use of g for the separate stop sound depends on the word's orthographic treatment.

ə / h · x / ch · r / g



Letters · L to Ž

Latin	Cyrillic / reading cue
L l	soft л
Ł ł	hard л
M m	м
N n	н
Ń ń	нь
O o	о
P p	п
R r	р
S s	с
Ś ś	сь
Š š	ш
T t	т
U u	у
Ů ů	ў
V v	в
Y y	ы
Z z · Ž ž · Ž ž	з · зь · ж

Before a vowel, i may signal softness. The letter l is already soft.
[2, 3]

Remember: ł = л, but ů = ў.



Letters working together

Combination	Example
ch = х	хата / chata
dz = дз	дзе / dzie
dž = дзь	мядзьведзь / miadźviedź
dž = дж	джэм / džem
šč = шч	шчупак / ščupak

Ch, dz and dž are stable combinations; šč represents a sequence of š + č. Dž marks softness. [2, 3]

Мядзьведзь is the classical spelling. Preserving modern мядзведзь gives miadzviedź instead. Keep the two source spellings distinct.

Read chata, džem and ščupak aloud; cover the examples and reconstruct their Cyrillic forms.

Caron: č, š, ž. Acute: ć, ħ, ś, ź.

Breve: ŷ.



The cover letter: Ŭ

Cyrillic	Łacinka
Беларусь	Bielaruś
беларусаў	bielarusau
слова	słova
слоў	słou
быў	byu
воўк	voŭk

Latin Ŭ ŭ corresponds to Belarusian Ў ў. Its mark is a breve: a small curve, not a straight bar. The base letter is U, not Y. [2, 3]

Ў does not form a separate syllable. English w offers a rough starting point; listening to Belarusian speech is better. [3]

*У / u and ў / ŭ are different.
Notice the letter in a complete word.*



Ł and L

Hard л: ł	Soft л: l
лапа / łapa	лямпa / lampa
лук / łuk	люк / luk
школа / szkoła	школьны / školny
бусел / busieł	соль / sol

The last consonant in busieł is hard; in sol it is soft. Before i, soft л is written l. [2, 3]

After soft l, use а, е, о, u for я, е, ё, ю: ля / la, ле / le, лё / lo, лю / lu. Do not add an extra i mechanically.

If you know Polish, take special care: Belarusian ł here represents hard л, not the usual modern Polish pronunciation of ł.

лес / les · лёд / lod · людзі / ludzi



Softness: acute or i?

Cyrillic	Łacinka
соль	sol
конь	koń
сябар	siabar
ціха	cicha
восень	vosień
піць	pić

At a word's end, an acute can mark softness: дзень / dzień, конь / koń, пісаць / pisać. There is no separate letter for Ъ. [2, 3]

Before a vowel, i usually does the work: ня / nia, ця / cia, ся / sia, зя / zia. Compare дзень / dzień with дня / dnia.

Do not add both an acute and i automatically. Check the consonant's position and the source spelling.

L is already soft: соль / sol.



Choosing j or i

Position	Writing
At the start	я / ja · е / je · ё / jo · ю / ju
After a vowel	мая / маја · знаю / знају
After a consonant	ня / нја · не / nie · нё / нjo · ню / niu
After soft l	ля / ла · ле / le · лё / lo · лю / lu

A separate й before a vowel is written j. The apostrophe is therefore not copied mechanically: сям'я / siamja, аб'ява / abjava, надвор'е / nadvorje. [3]

Find the vowel, examine what precedes it, then check separately for l and for a distinct j sound.

яма / jama · мая / маја

няма / niama · лямпя / lampja



One script, several choices

Modern source / rendering	Classical source / rendering
снег / snieh	сьнег / śnieh
свет / sviet	сьвет / śviet
песня / piesnia	песяня / pieśnia

Classical orthography marks assimilative softness in some positions where modern spelling does not. The difference may already exist in the Cyrillic source. [3, 4]

Choose a main approach for your notebook and label other spellings when quoting them.

Traditional łacinka is not identical to geographical romanization systems: its distinction between ł and l is one useful sign. [2, 9]

Choose the source spelling first.

Then choose the letters.



Words to keep

Cyrillic	Łacinka	English
бусел	busieł	stork
гняздо	hniazdo	nest
птушка	ptuška	bird
раніца	ranica	morning
восень	vosień	autumn
дрэва	dreva	tree
возера	voziera	lake
слова	słova	word
мова	mova	language
кніга	kniha	book
літара	litara	letter
дзякуй	dziakuj	thank you

Copy five words, then add one of your own. Stress is not marked here. Apply the rules on pages 8-14.

A first line:

бусел / busieł · гняздо / hniazdo



A stork by the house

Раніца. Каля хаты стаіць дрэва. На дрэве гняздо. У гняздзе
бусел. Я гляджу на птушку і пішу ў кнізе: «Добры дзень!»

Ranica. Kala chaty staić dreva. Na drevie hniazdo. U hniazdzie
busieł. Ja hladžu na ptušku i pišu Ź knizie: «Dobry dzień!»

Morning. A tree stands by the house. There is a nest in the tree
and a stork in the nest. I look at the bird and write in the book:
'Good day!'

Original practice text, not a literary quotation. Find ch, dz, dž, soft
l, ie and Ź. Copy three words you recognized without the Cyrillic.

Why kala, but slova?

The л in каля is soft; in слова it is hard.



Try it yourself

1. Write in łacinka: хата, бусел, гняздо, воўк, дзень, людзі.
2. Restore Cyrillic: mała, les, lod, dziakuj, vosień, pišu.
3. Insert ł or l: __uk (лук), __uk (люк), busie__ (бусел), so__ (соль).
4. Choose: яма - јама or іама? Няма - нјама or ніама? Мая - маја or маіа?
5. Write two sentences about a bird or a book. Start in Cyrillic, then use łacinka. Check each soft consonant.

Answers are on page 20.

Try first without the chart.



Look a little closer

6. Find the error: shata for хата; belarus for Беларусь; slova for слова.
7. Explain: u / ŭ; c / č; s / ś / š.
8. Write in łacinka: сям'я, надвор'е, я, ця, лёд.
9. Preserve each source spelling: снег; сьнег; песня; песьня.
10. An old edition uses sz and w. Must its language be Polish? How would you check?

An unfamiliar spelling is an invitation to investigate.



Your answer key

1. chata, busieł, hniazdo, voŭk, dzień, ludzi.
2. мала, лес, лёд, дзякуй, восень, пішу.
3. łuk; luk; busieł; sol.
4. jama; niama; maja.
5. One answer: Гэта кніга. Тут бусел. / Heta kniha. Tut busieł.
6. chata; Biełaruś; słowa. Check x, ie, ł and final ś.
7. y / ў; ц / ч; с / съ / ш.
8. siamja, nadvorje, ja, cia, lod.
9. snieh; śnieh; piesnia; pieśnia.
10. No. These can be historical łacinka conventions. Check the language, title, date and edition.

Name the rule, then make one new example.



Letters by hand

Write slowly: Ũ ů · Ł ł · Ć ć · Ń ń · Ś ś · Ż ż · Č č · Š š · Ž ž.

Keep the curved breve, slanted acute and angled caron distinct.
Do not let the stroke of ł disappear into a ruled line.

Then write busieł, hniazdo and Biełaruś. Add a date and a sentence of your own.

Date · subject · source

Leave room to change your mind.



Seven quiet sessions

Day	Ten minutes
1	Letters and five familiar words
2	Ŭ and u: notice the difference
3	Ł and l: copy a short line
4	Ć, ń, ś, ź: final softness
5	J and i: five vowel examples
6	Read the stork passage aloud
7	Repeat the drills without help

Next, try a poem. Start with a few lines, not a whole anthology.
Notice which letters now feel familiar.

Keep one question for later research.

Read a page. Discover why it looks the way it does.



Wind, falcon, and I

Вецер, і сокал, і я... / Viecier, i sokał, i ja...

This is the closest match to the book's theme: flight embodies a spirit that remains free despite constraint. The following excerpt follows the Cyrillic text in Kupala's collected works, volume 1 (1995), as presented by Belarusian Palichka. [12]

Як вецер, свабодны мой дух,
Хоць рукі закуты ў ланцуг.

Jak viecier, svabodny moj duch,
Choć ruki zakuty Ź łancuh.

English sense: My spirit is free as the wind, though my hands are chained.

The łacinka here is our modern reading transcription, not a facsimile of an early edition. Other editions have a different second line; we do not mix them.

v i e c i e r · Ź · ł

Notice ie, short Ź and hard ł.



A prayer to the wind

Мая малітва / Maja malitva

Choose the poem beginning «Ба ўсяку мінуту...». Kupala wrote more than one poem with this title. This one addresses sun, wind, water, sky and the wider world. [13]

Малюся свабоднаму ветру—віхуры,
Што лётае птушкай ад краю да краю,

Malusia svabodnamu vietru-vichury,
Što lotaje ptuškaj ad kraju da kraju,

English sense: I pray to the free whirlwind, flying like a bird from one edge of the world to the other.

The Cyrillic excerpt follows the 1926 collected-edition text on Wikisource. The łacinka transcription and English sense are prepared for this reader; neither is presented as an original historical translation.

лёмае / lotaje · птушкай / ptuškaj
After soft l, ě becomes o.



Freedom and open space

СЫМОН-МУЗЫКА / Symon-muzyka

A passage from a longer poem, rather than a separate lyric. It fits the book's theme through the artist's longing for freedom and room to live and create. [14]

Волі, волі і прастору!
Прэч граніцы!

Voli, voli i prastoru!
Preč hranicy!

English sense: Freedom, freedom and open space! Away with boundaries!

This is a short excerpt. The source inspected is Cyrillic; the łacinka is our modern transcription, not evidence that this edition was originally printed in Latin letters.

Look for the full passage in the linked source. Read around it to discover who is speaking and what freedom means in the scene.

волі / voli · прастору / prastoru

Which word would you keep in your notebook?



A little poetry notebook

Read for...	Begin with...
Inner freedom	Viecier, i sokał, i ja...
Sky and spiritual address	Maja malitva
An artist's longing	Symon-muzyka

These are Belarusian poems you can read in łacinka; the short transcriptions here were made for this book. A poet's connection with Latin-script publishing does not prove that every poem first appeared in that script.

For a historical Latin-script book, explore Kupala's Huślar (1910). Its spelling differs from this reader. Check the specific page rather than silently replacing the letters. [8]

For each new poem, keep four notes: author and title; edition; exact original lines; your own reading and response.

*What does flight mean here:
escape, discovery, return, or belonging?*



Sources to explore

[1] Volha Haryckaja, History of Belarusian Letters (2016). letters.philology.by

[2] Belarusian Institute of Arts and Sciences, Canada: Transliteration.
binim.org/index.php/transliteration/

[3] S. Aleksandrov and H. Mycyk: Belarusian alphabet, letters and sounds.
knihi.com/storage/padrucnik/alfabet_ru.htm

[4] Skaryna Library: Branislaŭ Taraškievič and his grammar.
skaryna.org/be/branislau-taraskievic/

[5] Belarusian Literature textbook, Bahuševič section.
padruchnik.com/books/id01987s/book_0.pdf

[6] Žalejka (1908), publisher's advertisement, Wikisource.

[7] Belarusian Association of Journalists: Mužyckaja praŭda. baj.media

[8-9] Supplementary script comparisons: Wikipedia. Historical Latin-page evidence: Hušlar (1910), Wikisource, page 64.

Full clickable references and editorial notes are in research/sources.md.

Consult the edition, not only the title.



Poetry & print notes

[12] Kupala: Viecei, i sokał, i ja... Belarusian Palichka; collected works, vol. 1 (1995). knihi.com/Janka_Kupala/

[13] Kupala: Maja malitva, collected edition, vol. II (1926), Wikisource; opening: «Ва ўсяку мінуту...».

[14] Kolas: Symon-muzyka. knihi.com/Jakub_Kolas/Symon-muzyka.html

English explanations, reading transcriptions, glosses and exercises were prepared for this edition. Poetry quotations are credited separately. Cover and stork vignettes are AI-generated watercolor illustrations.

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